

Contributions of international education to graduate capital and employability: Evidence from social science graduates in Kazakhstan

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ABSTRACT

Drawing on Tomlinson's graduate capital model, this paper examines the contribution of international education to the development of different forms of graduate capital and the experiences of international education graduates in applying graduate capital while navigating the job market. Interviews with 50 social science graduates in Kazakhstan demonstrated that human, social, and psychological capitals played a greater role in adjusting to various labour market factors and securing employment. We also contend that the utilization of specific forms of capital was contingent upon the particular industry where participants were seeking career opportunities.

1. Introduction

Many developing nations invest heavily in graduate capital development to ensure global competitiveness in a knowledge-based world. In Kazakhstan, international education is one of the key suppliers of the domestic talent pool (Nazarbayev, 2012). The country needs young, well-educated people equipped with global skills who can transform Kazakhstan into a modern advanced economy and ensure that it reaches its strategic goal of becoming one of the most developed countries by 2050 (Nazarbayev, 2012). In view of this, for almost 30 years, the government of Kazakhstan has sponsored an educational scholarship program called Bolashak, which enables young people to obtain higher education in reputable overseas universities. Furthermore, an international higher education institution that provides full-ride scholarships, Nazarbayev University (NU), was established in the capital city more than 10 years ago. Nazarbayev University operates with the principles of autonomy and academic freedom and offers western-style education which emphasizes development of critical thinking skills and global competences through western practices and standards in teaching and research. The university faculty members come from 58 countries and all programs are delivered through English medium instruction. To date, the Bolashak and NU programs have more than 11000 (Togaybayev, 2022) and almost 7000 (Kapital, 2021) alumni, respectively.

While acknowledging that the term “international education” has broader implications beyond Western-style education, in the context of this study, the terms “international” and “Western” are used interchangeably to reflect the prevalence of this specific type of educational model at NU. In particular, NU, while being Western-style education institution, is characterized by its focus on universally valued skills, inclusive environment, and active participation in international academic collaborations. Therefore, the descriptor “international education” aptly applies to it. However, this perspective does not dismiss the existence of diverse educational approaches within international contexts.

The Kazakhstani government anticipates a return on its investment when Bolashak and NU scholars graduate and start working towards contributing to the country's technological and economic development. Bolashak alumni are obliged to return to and work in Kazakhstan for a specific period, which varies depending on their place of residence and service, and significantly affects graduates' career paths. For graduates who decide to work in the country's most developed cities—Astana, Almaty, or Shymket—the service duration is five years. It is two years for those working in civil service or educational institutions in regions, and three years in other industries. While NU alumni do not have such contractual obligations, all recipients of state grants in Kazakhstan are obliged to work in the country for three years, giving them more

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flexibility in choosing their workplace upon graduation.

While the Bolashak program grants scholarships in various fields, STEM applicants used to receive fewer scholarships compared to those studying social sciences and humanities (Egemen Qazaqstan, 2020; Ignatova, 2017). Initially, there was no regulation on the allocation of scholarships based on fields of study, resulting in an uneven distribution. However, starting in 2020, the priority specialties list was aligned with the Ministry of Labour and Social Protection of Population's mid-term market forecast, enabling more students to study in high-demand technical and IT fields.

In 2022, the Bolashak program was reoriented towards technical disciplines; thus, 60% of scholarships are now granted to study natural sciences, engineering, etc. (Aitzhanova, 2022). However, journalists and experts have argued that the country still needs qualified professionals in the social sciences and humanities because the goal of transforming Kazakhstan's economic, social, and legislative systems has not yet been achieved (Togaybayev, 2022; Velichko, 2022). Furthermore, university graduates with international education still experience difficulties in obtaining employment upon graduation and in applying the knowledge and skills gained at university to the workplace (Dubova, 2020; Mustoyapova, 2019). The majority of media articles that discuss the employment-related issues of international graduates focus on the negative experiences of natural science and engineering graduates, who struggle to apply new knowledge in Kazakhstan because of outdated technology and equipment (Ramazanov, 2018; Ten, 2021; Velichko, 2022). Few studies have examined the specific issues faced by social science graduates (Caravan, 2018).

Studies differentiating between STEM and social science graduates' experiences remain limited (Abeuova and Muratbekova-Touron, 2019; Kuzhabekova et al., 2019). Despite 55% of all Bolashak alumni having studied social sciences and humanities (Togaybayev, 2022), no study has focused on the challenges they face. Statistics show that Kazakhstan's labor market has been oversupplied with social science graduates (Khabar24, 2021; Manayev, 2022), especially in economics and law (Informburo, 2022). Furthermore, social sciences and humanities graduates tend to face greater employment-related issues than those who study natural sciences and engineering (Chen et al., 2022; Monteiro et al., 2020; Okay-Somerville and Scholarios, 2015). This might be explained by the increased demand for STEM professionals in the labor market (Monteiro et al., 2020) and the specificity of generic fields, which often require work experience to understand possible career paths (Okay-Somerville and Scholarios, 2015). While it is evident that social science graduates experience difficulties transitioning from university to the workplace, research on their employment experiences in Kazakhstan and in the post-Soviet context remains scarce. Our study addresses this gap by analyzing the job experiences of Bolashak and NU social science alumni and identifying the challenges they face when securing employment. Specifically, we aim to address the following questions: (1) What is the contribution of international education to the development of different forms of graduate capital? (2) What are the experiences of international education graduates in applying various forms of graduate capital while navigating the job market? We utilize Tomlinson's (2017) graduate capital model as a guiding framework and a theoretical lens for structuring the analyses of both existing literature and the interview data.

2. Forms of graduate capital developed via international education received abroad and at home

As international education is often associated with increased employability and possession of in-demand global skills, it remains one of the key aspects of reform agendas worldwide. To boost human capital and economic development, governments introduce scholarships for their citizens to pursue education abroad, e.g. Bolashak program in Kazakhstan and the King Abdullah Scholarship Program in Saudi Arabia, or establish international universities and branch campuses at home, e.

g. Nazarbayev University in Kazakhstan or international branch campuses in Malaysia. The idea that local students have the opportunity to gain an international higher education experience without traveling abroad refers to the "internationalization at home" (Harrison, 2015). This concept emphasizes that these students can attain an international educational experience through engaging with international students, internationalized curriculum, and innovative teaching methods. In contrast to the internationalization abroad, the research on internationalization at home remains scarce though it is believed to be one of the key aspects of internationalization nowadays (Beelen and Jones, 2015; De Wit and Altbach, 2021). It should be noted that while international education abroad and at home seem to produce similar learning outcomes, several studies pointed out the limited capacity of at-home programs in developing transnational skills (Belderbos, 2020; Sin, 2013). Therefore, internationalization at home cannot be considered as an entire replacement for study abroad programs. The analysis of existing literature shows that international education received both abroad and at home contribute to the development of various forms of capital classified by Tomlinson (2017).

2.1. Human capital

International education received both abroad and at home is generally believed to facilitate development of human capital in a form of advanced knowledge and skills (Belderbos, 2020; Cai, 2012; Cheong et al., 2016; Mellors-Bournes et al., 2015; Thieme, 2014; Xiong and Mok, 2020) and English language proficiency (Belderbos, 2020; Cheong et al., 2016; Hao et al., 2016; Koda and Yuki, 2013; Perna et al., 2015). Multiple studies report that both diplomas, obtained overseas and at international universities in home countries, are highly valued in the local job market (Belderbos, 2020; Cai, 2012; Campbell, 2017; Hao et al., 2016; Jonbekova et al., 2021, 2023; Xiong and Mok, 2020). For example, in Kyrgyzstan international education positively impacted the careers of social science graduates due to the acquired knowledge and skills (Thieme, 2014).

Literature suggests that returnee graduates and those with international qualifications earned domestically face increased competition from both international and local graduates in the labor market (Abimbola et al., 2016; Hao et al., 2016; Robertson et al., 2011; Xiong and Mok, 2020; Zhai and Gao, 2021). Another issue is education-job mismatch. Social science graduates interviewed by Nachatar Singh (2020), especially those who studied accounting and finance, worked in positions that were not connected to their fields of study because of limited work experience in their home country. The same is true for locally educated international graduates: Mellors-Bournes et al. (2015) reported that graduates who studied law could not find a job in the related field and had to work in other industries to make a living. International graduates who studied abroad may also be overqualified for their jobs (Bonilla and Kwak, 2015; Cai, 2012).

2.2. Social capital

Reportedly, both forms of international education contribute to the formation of social capital through expansion of personal and professional networks (Ferguson and Sonnenschein, 2020; Sin, 2013). Well-developed relationships with key stakeholders might lead to introductions and recommendations to potential employers and therefore are considered to be beneficial. However, several studies report that graduates educated abroad experience lost networks and connections in their home country which put them at a disadvantage on the domestic job market (Ferguson and Sonnenschein, 2020; Pham and Saito, 2019). Meanwhile, graduates who opted for an international study within their home country acknowledged that it offered them "the best of both worlds" - obtaining world-class academic credentials while enabling a stronger connection with local values and societal norms (Sin, 2013, p. 859).

2.3. Cultural capital

International education equips graduates with the knowledge of practices, attitudes and communication rules applicable to business relationships in the modern globalized world which constitute cultural capital (Hao and Welch, 2012; Hao et al., 2016; Mellors-Bournes et al., 2015). This makes international graduates noticeably attractive among international employers. However, there is a body of research that shows that poor understanding of local norms and networking styles might inhibit international graduates' career paths upon return to their home countries (Cai, 2012; Hao et al., 2016; Tran et al., 2021). They may also experience reverse culture shock and have to readapt to local conditions (Perna et al., 2015; Pham and Saito, 2019). Furthermore, organizational boundaries that encompass rigid cultures and inadequate workplace conditions were faced by both overseas and locally educated international graduates. Studies in developing countries reveal that these graduates face challenges in applying their knowledge and skills due to inflexible and toxic work environments (Bonilla and Kwak, 2015; Jonbekova et al., 2021, 2023; Perna et al., 2015; Pham and Saito, 2019; Mellors-Bournes et al., 2015). Misalignment with the principles of those in power have also been reported to hinder graduates' efforts in the workplace. In Georgia, for example, alumni quit their jobs in the government as their principles do not align with their senior leadership (Campbell, 2017).

2.4. Identity capital

International education plays a role in developing identity capital which is related to career management skills and graduates' self-presentation and navigation in the job market (Mellors-Bournes et al., 2015). One of the advantages associated with international education is possession of a prestigious diploma (Belderbos, 2020; Mellors-Bournes et al., 2015). Thus, research conducted in Kazakhstan indicated that both groups of graduates - with international academic credentials earned abroad and those attained at a local international university - were regarded higher by domestic employers than alumni from non-international domestic universities (Jonbekova et al., 2021). However, graduates educated abroad enjoyed a slightly greater reputational advantage than those who obtained international education "at home". Similarly, a study in Malaysia revealed that international education acquired domestically was placed in the middle strata of the hierarchy sandwiched between overseas education at the top and Malaysian public education at the lower end (Sin, 2013). However, a prestigious diploma and increased ambitions might lead to unrealistic salary expectations that prevent some employers from hiring international graduates (Cai, 2012; Perna et al., 2015; Pham, 2021; Tran et al., 2021). Tran et al. (2021) reported that Chinese employers hesitate to hire accounting graduates from Australia because of their egos and unrealistically inflated expectations.

2.5. Psychological capital

Psychological capital in a form of increased self-confidence, resilience and improved personal attributes is also gained through international education (Belderbos, 2020; Hoare, 2012; Perna et al., 2015; Sin, 2013). These qualities empower international graduates to handle various challenges in an effective way. For instance, high expectations from locals that international graduates seem to encounter (Ferguson and Sonnenschein, 2020; Franken et al., 2016; Xiong and Mok, 2020). Thus, Australian graduates in the Chinese hospitality industry mentioned the pressure to meet language skill expectations from managers and colleagues (Ferguson and Sonnenschein, 2020). Another example is balancing work and personal life which poses a challenge for many female graduates, hindering their career advancement (Enkhtur, 2019; Pham and Saito, 2019). As primary caregivers in their households, women face additional responsibilities that make it harder to establish a

successful career. Moreover, gender biases such as the perception of reliability and leadership as purely masculine traits create extra hurdles for female international graduates when it comes to securing employment (Sin, 2013). In each of those situations, graduates have to demonstrate resilience and perseverance to move forward in their career.

Moving from the practical outcomes discussed in prior literature, the subsequent section delves into Tomlinson's (2017) graduate capital model, providing a theoretical lens to further analyze the nuanced dimensions of graduates' experiences in the context of Kazakhstan. Fig. 1.

3. Theoretical framework

Tomlinson's (2017) graduate capital model serves as our study's guiding framework. It enables us to examine how international education equipped alumni with human, social, cultural, identity, and psychological capital, and how these were used to secure employment.

According to this model, human capital is concerned with knowledge and skills acquired through formal education (Tomlinson, 2017), which are believed to increase productivity and, thus, employability. Nevertheless, it is crucial for graduates to effectively communicate to their employer how their subject knowledge and generic skills can be applied to real-world situations in the workplace.

Social capital refers to graduates' social relationships and networks that facilitate their transition from academia to the workplace. Granovetter (1985) concept of strong and weak ties is crucial for understanding the impact of connections in building trust, sharing information, and gaining insider knowledge. Strong ties, such as family members or close acquaintances, provide firsthand job information through their networks. However, even weak ties with a broader range of social connections can be advantageous in securing employment. The greater the diversity of connections, the more opportunities for employment a graduate can access.

Cultural capital encompasses knowledge, attitudes, and behaviors valued in a specific workplace (Tomlinson, 2017). Noteworthy, achievements such as field-specific awards and conference participation can enhance a graduate's profile during recruitment (Lindberg, 2013). Hence, cultural capital aligned with employer's cultural norms, values, and expectations can increase employability.

Identity capital can be conceived as the effort and resources graduates put into building career prospects and making themselves more desirable to potential employers (Tomlinson, 2017). The ability to form and present a solid career identity can give graduates a competitive advantage in the labour market.

Psychological capital, which is rooted in psychological and social resources, can help graduates develop self-efficacy, adaptability, and resilience to proactively overcome challenges that arise in their careers (Tomlinson, 2017). It can strengthen their perseverance throughout the job search process and help them attain career goals, withstand stress, and cope with setbacks, thus enhancing their chances of securing and retaining employment.

Considering that both Bolashak and NU scholarships were created to develop a skilled workforce to stimulate sustainable domestic economic growth, Tomlinson's (2017) graduate capital model can help identify the relationship between international education and labor market outcomes. Specifically, this study uses the model to analyze the contribution of international education to the development of different forms of graduate capital and the experiences of international education graduates in applying the accumulated capital, individually or in conjunction, to successfully navigate the labor market.

4. Methodology

This study investigates the employment experiences of social science graduates who have obtained international education through government scholarships and are currently pursuing their careers in

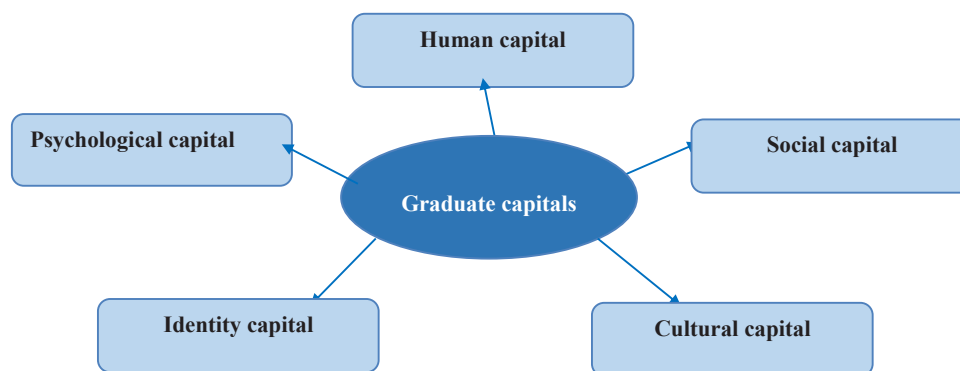


Fig. 1. Tomlinson's (2017) graduate capital model.

Kazakhstan. To capture a broader diversity in the employment experiences of social science graduates, participants were selected using purposeful maximal variation sampling (Creswell, 2012) based on the following criteria: those who received a full governmental scholarship to study at the master's level, those who were living and working full-time in Kazakhstan, and those who had at least three years of work experience at the moment of the interview. We included participants with variations in (1) gender, (2) host country, (3) social science major, (4) workplace type, and (5) geographical location. The participants' characteristics are detailed in Table 1.

To focus on the initial professional progress of government scholarship recipients, we chose graduates who recently completed their studies between 2015 and 2017. The population consisted of 217 NU alumni and 599 Bolashak alumni specializing in social sciences. Initially, around 250 prospective participants were approached via email and Facebook. This initial contact aimed to reach a diverse pool of individuals who might qualify for the study. As a result, 50 alumni—35 from Bolashak and 15 from NU—expressed their willingness to participate. These participants were then engaged in one-on-one interviews conducted in a semi-structured format. Each interview lasted for around one hour and was audio-recorded with the consent of the participants. Owing to the COVID-19 pandemic, all interviews were conducted online between January and March 2021 using various platforms such as Zoom, Skype, and WhatsApp.

The recorded interviews were manually transcribed. Prior to initiating the data analysis process, a set of preliminary measures were taken with the interview transcripts. These included assigning a code to each participant to de-identify the data, properly labeling each transcript file, and securely storing them on a Google Drive accessible solely to the research team.

The data analysis was grounded in Corbin and Strauss (2015) three-stage model of coding, which includes open coding, axial coding,

and selective coding (Table 2). The research team initiated the open coding phase by meticulously reviewing the transcripts line by line and assigning descriptive terms and phrases to segments of text.

During the axial coding stage, open codes that shared common attributes were grouped together to form categories (Cohen et al., 2018; Corbin and Strauss, 2015). For this purpose, the researchers gathered all open codes into a single file, scrutinizing them thoroughly and seeking underlying dimensions that could connect various codes. Specifically, the research team employed the constant comparative method, which entails a thorough examination of data segments to reveal commonalities and distinctions, ultimately facilitating their classification into specific categories (Glaser and Strauss, 2006).

The third stage – selective coding – involved careful analysis of the axial codes and their combination into the final themes.

5. Results

5.1. Overall employment experience

Bolashak and NU social science graduates smoothly transitioned from academia to professional careers, either returning to their previous workplaces or securing new employment within six months of graduation. Some graduates were quickly offered job opportunities upon their return to Kazakhstan, and in some cases, they were hired without having to apply. This speedy employment can be attributed to the graduates' extensive knowledge and transferable skills, giving them an advantage over their peers with local academic credentials.

Once I earned my master's degree, I had three options: return to my previous job or start working in a government agency that offered me a job immediately upon graduation. In addition, during my studies, I applied for and was accepted by the United Nations Young Professionals Program. (NU 2, Business Administration, Astana).

Table 1
Participants characteristics.

Scholarship	Bolashak	NU					
Gender	35 Male	15 Female					
Host Country	26 Kazakhstan	24 UK	8 US	3 Europe	1 Australia	1 Russia	
Area of Specialization	15 Public Policy/ Political Science	22 Economics/Finance/ Banking/ Accounting	7 Education	5 Business Administration	3 Tourism/ Hospitality Management	3 Management and Innovation	6 Other
Type of Workplace	14 Private Company	12 Quasipublic Company	11 HEI	7 International Organization	6 National Company	3 Civil Service	
Region Where Currently Based	12 Astana	11 Almaty	11 Atyrau	7 Aktau	6 Akmola Region	3	
	38	9	1	1	1		

Table 2
Coding process.

Coding stage	Codes/Categories/Themes								
1. Open	advanced hard skills/subject knowledge; practical orientation; prestigious diploma; international experience; access to resources; promotion opportunities; higher salary	professional jealousy; poor facilities and equipment; limited authority at workplace; lack of managerial support; bureaucracy; back-door games; hierarchical culture; resistance to change; nepotism; intergenerational clashes; lack of transparency; gender biases; underdeveloped industries; financial crisis; skills mismatch	prestigious company; higher position; professional development; ambitious projects; staff reduction; desire to change the field	education; banking and finance; civil service; mining; oil and gas; audit and consulting; telecommunications; agriculture; tourism; filmmaking; media; social work; transportation	hard skills/subject knowledge; critical thinking; analytical skills; communication skills; collaboration skills; time management; change management; intercultural competence; research skills; leadership skills; negotiation skills; creative thinking; English language skills; reputation of diploma; master's degree	networking; professional international community; insider knowledge of jobs	self-efficacy; resilience; adaptability; flexibility	proactive job market strategies; presentation of employable-self; work-related achievements and experiences	integration into organization; knowledge of organizational culture
2. Axial	benefits of international education	employment-related challenges	reason for changing jobs	occupational fields	human capital	social capital	cultural capital	identity capital	psychological capital
3. Selective	overall employment experience								
	graduate capitals								

Participants secured jobs across diverse industries, with a significant portion working in education as teachers or administrators in schools and universities. Other employment sectors included banking, finance, civil service, mining, telecommunications, and agriculture. Bolashak alumni who obtained their scholarship under the “University Graduate” category had to sign an agreement with the Bolashak program and their local university, obligating them to work in their domestic alma mater after graduation. This requirement contributed to the high number of education-related jobs.

Most participants remained with a single employer or switched jobs only once after graduation. However, some social science alumni changed workplaces at least three times, primarily driven by the prospects of professional growth and career advancement. These graduates were predominantly located in Astana or Almaty, cities with a greater number of prominent employers and a wider range of job prospects. The concentration of major employers in these cities likely increased their willingness to take the risk of job switching compared to their counterparts in smaller and less developed cities.

I have worked there for two years. I left because I did not experience any professional growth or development. I did not learn anything from the people with whom I worked. As my professional development stagnated, I decided to join another company. (Bolashak 31, Accounting and Finance, Astana).

Both Bolashak and NU graduates had generally positive experiences of securing employment. The successful transition of social science alumni can be attributed to their high-quality international education, which equipped them with various forms of capital that factored into their increased employability.

5.2. International education, graduate capitals, and employment

5.2.1. Human capital: Transferable skills, subject knowledge, intercultural competences, English language proficiency and underdeveloped industries

Bolashak and NU graduates outlined several factors related to human capital that enhanced their prospects for success in the job market. These factors included transferable skills and subject knowledge.

An overwhelming majority of social science alumni concurred that transferable skills, such as research, critical thinking, and communication, were the most significant factor that enhanced their employability. Research skills aided in finding the required information promptly, analyzing and structuring data, performing statistical analysis, and looking at an issue from multiple perspectives. Meanwhile, critical thinking skills encouraged them to question the status quo and initiate changes. Effective communication skills were essential for creating a vibrant work environment and building relationships with colleagues.

The advantage of master's programs abroad is that they are predominantly based on teamwork and various collaborations; thus, one can build, shape, manage, and supervise how each team member works. (Bolashak 9, Strategic Project Management, Almaty).

In contrast to their NU peers, Bolashak graduates attached considerable importance to intercultural competence, which helped them effectively collaborate with individuals from diverse cultural backgrounds. Due to spending substantial time abroad, Bolashak graduates had greater opportunities to encounter different cultures and develop cross-cultural acumen. Conversely, while NU graduates experienced an international atmosphere on campus, their external environment often exposed them to the same cultural milieu, resulting in fewer chances to foster skills related to cross-cultural and transnational interactions.

It is such an experience. I am happy that I was able to get it. You see how people from other countries look at a situation differently; everyone has their own culture and a different attitude toward work. I now work for a company that frequently cooperates with foreigners from China, France, and Korea... I know how to approach people from a particular country. (Bolashak 16, International Economy, Astana).

Subject knowledge enabled effective job performance and broadened graduates' responsibilities, making them valuable assets for employers.

Participants indicated that such subject knowledge could not have been obtained without international education.

Without studying abroad and having knowledge of Western media, I could not conduct such interviews and write such articles. (Bolashak 22, International Journalism, Astana).

Unlike their NU counterparts, many Bolashak graduates attributed their increased employability to improved English language proficiency, which enabled them to effectively collaborate with international partners and colleagues, and apply best international practices in their workplace. Having lived abroad and gained extensive English language experience, many Bolashak graduates may have sought job opportunities where they could utilize this skill.

In the case of Bolashak alumni, their career pathways were aggravated by underdeveloped fields such as hospitality, economics, and finance and investment. Graduates noted that despite significant government investment in promoting Kazakhstan as a travel destination, the hospitality industry remained underdeveloped, resulting in limited opportunities for those with relevant academic qualifications. Similarly, finance and investment graduates struggled to find employment due to the poor state of Kazakhstan's securities and investment markets.

Although my specialty was Accounting and Finance, the emphasis was on finance, specifically the securities and investment markets, but Kazakhstan's securities market is not developed. (Bolashak 23, Accounting and Finance, Astana).

Beyond developing transferable skills and subject knowledge, the findings illuminate the importance of understanding different cultures and being proficient in English, thus reflecting the globalized nature of contemporary workplaces. Furthermore, the challenges faced by the participants, particularly in underdeveloped sectors, underscore the need for strategic alignment between academic programs and industry demands, urging a reevaluation of educational strategies to better equip graduates for the demands of a constantly evolving job market.

5.2.2. Social capital

Networking emerged as a significant theme in our analysis, highlighting the importance of social capital. The majority of Bolashak and NU social science graduates emphasized that the networks they established while pursuing their master's degrees assisted them in identifying skilled professionals for their projects and expediting work-related processes, which helped advance their careers. Additionally, some participants highlighted that these networks provided them with avenues of possibilities, such as participating in ambitious projects, meeting distinguished figures in their respective fields, and accessing top employers at job fairs.

In a professional sense, I built certain connections with the university and my classmates who have returned to their own countries. They are professionals with whom I keep in touch. I sometimes use these connections for my work... In Britain, for example, they have already thought through certain issues, such as distance learning, while Kazakhstan is only now transitioning to this learning format. Since I have already witnessed how distance learning was implemented in Britain, it became much easier for me to handle the same transition in Kazakhstan. (Bolashak 12, Media and Public Relations, Astana).

Upon graduation and return to Kazakhstan, many Bolashak graduates were immediately offered jobs by their former employers which implies they had no difficulties associated with lost networks at their home country. Not only did they expand their networks internationally, but they also preserved existing relationships back in Kazakhstan. These findings can be explained by the fact that Bolashak graduates were fully aware of their contractual obligation to come back and work in Kazakhstan, so that they stayed in touch with their former colleagues. Former work experience and earned reputation coupled with a prestigious diploma made them attractive on the job market. In contrast, only a few NU graduates mentioned networking as the primary source of obtaining employment. This limited engagement in networking among NU graduates may stem from their local study experience, which lacked

exposure to a diverse range of individuals compared to their Bolashak peers, who had an opportunity to build networks both domestically and internationally. Another contributing factor could be the absence of contractual employment commitments for NU alumni, potentially resulting in a reduced emphasis on networking as the predominant method of securing employment.

5.2.3. Cultural capital: Familiarity with the workplace culture, hierarchical and bureaucratic management styles, resistance to change and nepotism

Several Bolashak and NU graduates could effortlessly secure employment or implement workplace changes due to their familiarity with the workplace culture and practices. Notably, most of them worked in education. These graduates either tried to find jobs or initiate changes in the education sector, which is known for its highly hierarchical structure. Having been aware of that, participants approached those at the top of the hierarchy. In other words, their knowledge that a culture of seniority works effectively in this extremely hierarchical academic environment helped them achieve their goals.

There was a big misunderstanding and resistance on the part of my colleagues because they were all accustomed to teaching old subjects... There was such resistance, but I had a simple lever that I skillfully used: I told them that it [change of the curriculum] was the initiative of the rector and dean. So, I just pushed my agenda, and they [colleagues] accepted and tried to adapt to it. (NU 8, Political Science and International Relations, Almaty).

Other fields where graduates were able to successfully navigate the workplace by being cognizant of workplace cultures were the civil service and quasi-public sector. According to the participants, knowing the workplace culture enabled them to easily meet employers' expectations and satisfy recruitment criteria.

On the negative side, Bolashak and NU graduates reported that such an organizational factor as hierarchical and bureaucratic management styles adversely affected their work experience. Participants encountered issues such as politicization, conservative practices, and poor decision-making at the workplace and believed that their experience could have been more positive without these barriers. Most participants who discussed bureaucratic management styles studied politics and talked predominantly about the civil service or quasi-public sector, which are known for their inflexible, politicized, and hierarchical culture that involves top-down decision-making and rigid procedures.

The challenges mentioned by both Bolashak and NU alumni included resistance to change and nepotism. Specifically, alumni coworkers' resistance to change was a significant barrier to promoting new ideas and approaches, especially in educational organizations, quasi-public companies, or civil services that traditionally have a hierarchical culture. Furthermore, the reluctance to challenge the status quo primarily came from elderly colleagues or those residing in small towns or rural areas. Given the rapid technological advancements, workplace innovations and changes often involve new technologies and automation, leading to skill obsolescence and the need to acquire new skills. The elderly and those in rural areas, who tend to be less proficient in new technologies, may prefer maintaining the status quo to avoid losing their jobs.

They [teachers] have been applying the same [academic] program for 40 years, and nothing else has changed but the cover. The content remained the same. It was very difficult to communicate to them that new technologies existed. People listened to us only because we had an order from the Ministry of Education and Science. (Bolashak 3, International Educational Management, Astana).

Some graduates commented that nepotism was widespread in Kazakhstan, particularly in civil service and large national companies. One participant who worked in the civil service noted the following:

Workplaces are highly politicized, and there is nepotism. Perhaps they will let us go up [the career ladder] to some point but will not, probably, let us go further. This is what I have observed in my workplace. (NU 10, Public Policy, Almaty).

Several NU alumni associated their work-related problems with the cultural environment of one specific field, civil service. They observed that structural issues deeply rooted in workplace culture affected their experience. Despite aspirations to bring about system changes and improve people's lives, civil service work proved to be extremely rigid, often falling short of young professionals' expectations.

5.2.4. Identity capital: Effective self-presentation on the job market

The findings showed that some Bolashak and NU graduates accumulated identity capital, such as the presentation of an employable self and work-related achievements and experiences. A number of participants used certain strategies to promote their employability, including crafting an appealing CV, developing self-presentation, communication, and negotiation skills that improved their confidence at the interview stage. Furthermore, they have built a reputation as a trustworthy and hard-working person and worked in different degree-related positions to create a multi-faceted professional identity. Moreover, they attended various degree-related summer schools, workshops, and seminars, and earned international academic credentials. Additionally, accumulating work-related achievements and experiences was crucial for career advancement, leading participants to seek reputable workplaces, engage in major projects, and gain substantial experience in their fields. Particularly, recognizing the advantage of prior employment with leading organizations in the sector for securing future employment, the graduates made concerted efforts to secure positions within those flagship companies.

Employers require experience with the Big Four. Previously, it simply involved having work experience with the Big Four. Now they require at least four years of experience in the Big Four. Since my experience is valued more [than a diploma], I have never had any problems with employment. (Bolashak 31, Accounting and Finance, Astana).

While both Bolashak and NU graduates stressed the importance of work-related achievements and experiences and of presenting themselves as professionals when securing employment, NU alumni also highlighted the need for proactive strategies in navigating the job market instead of relying solely on passive opportunities. This proactive mindset may be influenced by their field of study, particularly Business Administration. The distinguishing characteristic of graduates in this discipline is their robust capacity to take initiative, create efficient problem-solving strategies, prioritize duties, and possess a strategic vision. Hence, the master's program has likely contributed to their strong agency. This finding also illustrates that Bolashak graduates benefit from a distinct edge in terms of the prestige and elevated worth associated with their overseas diplomas. This favorable positioning obviates the necessity for them to engage in job securing strategies as extensively as their counterparts from NU.

Education provides instruments and tools to develop and promote oneself, but what is more important is who you are, how you can manage your career, and what kind of opportunities you can create for yourself. Throughout my professional life, I have created career opportunities for myself instead of waiting to receive them from others. (NU 3, Business Administration, Astana).

Notably, all Bolashak and NU graduates who underscored the significance of work-related achievements and experiences, and were able to present an employable self, were from either Astana or Almaty. While these cities accumulate the majority of key employers and large-scale projects and, therefore, offer more job opportunities, they are also home to highly competitive labor markets. Thus, relevant work experience and effective self-marketing play crucial roles in securing an ideal job there.

Furthermore, a prestigious university diploma was an important factor in enhancing alumni employability and success in the local job market. International academic credentials gave the participants a competitive advantage during the screening stage and helped them earn a certain degree of credibility. However, although both groups'

academic qualifications were valued by employers, the graduates with overseas diplomas were more likely to receive favorable treatment in the job market. The elevated regard for foreign diplomas could be partially attributed to an issue deeply ingrained within the post-Soviet society, where certain employers exhibit a tendency of uncritically assuming anything originating from the West as a credible and reliable benchmark, particularly conspicuous in the Finance sector. Specifically, Western countries often play a central role in the global financial system. Financial institutions, regulations, and practices originating from the West can have a widespread impact on the international financial landscape. As a result, professionals in the Finance sector may view credentials from the West as indicative of a broader understanding of global financial markets.

There are more doors opening for you. If you say that you graduated from a foreign university, you immediately see a favorable attitude when you are applying for a job. You send your CV, and those who did not invite you before, start inviting you. (Bolashak 19, Banking and Finance, Astana).

Additionally, according to some participants, NU graduates lacked a competitive advantage in the civil service compared to Bolashak graduates, who secured positions based on the prestige of their diplomas.

Two years ago, when I was working at the ministry, my degree from Nazarbayev University did not bring me any benefits. For example, Bolashak graduates have certain privileges in terms of the length of service and rankings or positions they can apply for... As a Nazarbayev University graduate, I did not have such privileges. (NU 2, Business Administration, Astana).

Our findings highlight the complex employability strategies of Bolashak and NU graduates, emphasizing the role of identity capital in shaping career trajectories. Additionally, the participants' accounts draw attention to the enduring influence of societal biases favoring overseas diplomas. These insights call for a wider discussion on the interplay of education, identity, and societal views, signaling the need for comprehensive strategies to assist graduates in navigating the changing professional landscape.

5.2.5. Psychological capital: Self-efficacy and resilience as key enablers and professional jealousy

Our findings indicate that international education fosters traits such as self-efficacy and adaptability that help graduates fulfill their career aspirations. Participants noted that, after completing a graduate degree program, they developed confidence in their professional capabilities due to their advanced knowledge and skills. Such self-efficacy made graduates feel more secure in their careers, confident in their ability to perform complex tasks, and competitive in both local and global job markets. Moreover, participants were able to make effective decisions at work, maintain a "nothing is impossible" attitude in the face of challenges and step outside their comfort zones. Overall, they exhibited a higher level of self-perceived employability.

I think that after obtaining this degree, I became more confident in my future. I realized that I could find a job at good companies not only in Kazakhstan but also abroad. This gave me confidence and freedom. (Bolashak 10, Finance and Investment, Astana).

This study also revealed that international education assisted graduates in developing the capacity to adapt to challenges and changes, as well as to deal with disputes. While reflecting on the knowledge and skills acquired while studying abroad, one participant noted,

What I have gained is the skills to be very flexible, easily adaptable to different situations, and to work under pressure. (Bolashak 1, Hospitality Management, Astana).

Unlike their Bolashak counterparts, NU alumni mentioned resilience as a contributing factor to employability. NU alumni noted that the challenges they faced during their graduate program made them more resistant to the issues and stressful situations they encountered at the workplace.

Interestingly, Bolashak graduates faced more frequent instances of

professional jealousy from their colleagues compared to their NU peers. Some colleagues treated them with suspicion and were hesitant to accept their ideas, assuming that those with international education were either showing off or seeking preferential treatment. This attitude can be partly attributed to negative stereotypes surrounding Bolashak graduates, who are believed to consider themselves an elite caste, and the Bolashak program itself—the fairness and effectiveness of which are often questioned by the general public.

When a young person joins the company and they [colleagues] see that he/she has fresh ideas that can be implemented... such ideas are negatively perceived by those who have been working there since before ... “you think you are a ‘know-it-all’ guy, you think you are smart, you think you graduated from a cool university and now we should all listen to you”—these are the kinds of encounters I have had with my colleagues. (Bolashak 32, International Political Economy, Astana).

Several female Bolashak and NU graduates identified gender-related issues that hindered their career development. Some reported family commitment as the major reason for career breaks and limited employment opportunities. This is not surprising because women in Kazakhstan play a primary role in childcare and housekeeping. The participants had to persevere through these challenges and stay on their career track.

Right now it is about family issues. You have a baby and you cannot control all the stuff. You have to stay at home and do some stuff at home, and be with your family, and try to raise a child. So for me personally, it is a maternity leave: I would say for now, it is not a full stop of the engine but just a little pit stop before the big jump. (NU 1, Business Administration, Astana).

The above findings underscore that international education extends beyond academic aspects, instilling graduates with self-efficacy and adaptability. Despite facing challenges like professional jealousy and gender issues, the participants were able to showcase resilience, which calls for the need to acknowledge the broader advantages of international education in fostering professionals prepared for diverse and dynamic work environments.

6. Discussion and conclusion

This study explored the career trajectories of social science graduates who earned academic credentials through government scholarships. Overall, Bolashak and NU graduates experienced a smooth transition from academia to their professional careers and enjoyed a reputational advantage in the domestic job market (Hao et al., 2016; Jonbekova et al., 2021; Xiong and Mok, 2020).

The study highlights that graduate capital (Tomlinson, 2017), including human, social, cultural, identity, and psychological, helped the participants secure employment in the domestic labor market. However, based on the participants' accounts, we argue that human, social, and psychological capitals played a greater role in adjusting to various labour market factors and securing employment. Specifically, transferable skills as human capital, networking as social capital, and self-efficacy as psychological capital were self-reported as the most critical to employment success. These findings make perfect sense considering the current economic situation in the world and Kazakhstan in particular: since many participants sought jobs during the financial crisis, transferable skills, social networks and self-efficacy helped graduates adapt to various workplace contexts and land a job. This implies that the concept of graduate employability is much broader than simply acquisition of subject-specific knowledge and skills as graduates need to be able to navigate the turbulent job market and adjust their skill sets throughout their career (Holmes, 2013). It seems reasonable that students expect universities to assist in developing relevant transferable skills, building networks and self-confidence which are critical in the rise of global economic uncertainty and that universities are capable of providing such assistance (Clarke, 2018). It suggests that more curricular and extracurricular activities with the focus on developing social,

cultural, identity, and psychological capitals should be incorporated into degree programs.

This study also found that international education from abroad contributed to a greater graduate capital development than international education “at home”. This stemmed from direct exposure of students to diverse cultures, interaction with native English speakers, and the perceived higher value of diploma from overseas in the local labor market. Although both Bolashak and NU graduates identified networks as major social capital that contributed to their employability, Bolashak alumni appeared to enjoy better opportunities coming from their networks internationally and domestically. This finding contradicts those of earlier studies (Ferguson and Sonnenschein, 2020; Hao et al., 2016; Pham and Saito, 2019; Tran et al., 2021), which suggested that individuals who studied overseas for an extended period lost their domestic networks and connections. The circumstances surrounding Bolashak graduates are unordinary because they have mandatory employment commitments in Kazakhstan. Bolashak alumni are fully aware of their eventual return home, so they actively work on building skills and resources that will enhance their prospects for finding employment inside their home country. This involves not only nurturing existing and forging new social connections within Kazakhstan (social capital) but also familiarizing themselves with the intricacies of the local job market (cultural capital) and establishing a reputation as dependable and dedicated individuals who are eager to prioritize their long-term career goals over immediate financial gains (identity capital).

One of the major findings of our study was that the utilization of specific forms of capital, either individually or in combination, was contingent upon the particular industry where participants were seeking career opportunities. In cases where the graduates were aiming to enter or navigate highly centralized and hierarchical workplaces, such as educational institutions, government agencies, or quasi-public organizations, they predominantly relied on social, cultural, and psychological assets. For instance, recognizing that these workplaces operated based on seniority-driven norms (cultural capital), the graduates made concerted efforts to approach and form alliances with those in top positions within the hierarchy (social and psychological capitals) to realize their career ambitions. In the meantime, those aspiring to build their careers within international organizations, which predominantly operate based on meritocracy, drew primarily upon their human and identity assets. The graduates directed their energies towards acquiring industry-specific expertise and skills (human capital) and cultivating a strong professional reputation (identity capital).

In unison with previous studies (Perna et al., 2015; Thieme, 2014), this study suggests that international education significantly boosts graduates' self-efficacy. The participants developed confidence in their subject knowledge and transferable skills, resulting in increased belief in their professional capabilities and perceived employability. Notably, a significant number of Bolashak social science alumni who reported increased self-efficacy were female. This could be attributed to the traditional gender bias in Kazakh society, where men are typically seen as superior. Therefore, studying abroad may have exposed female Bolashak alumni to a more gender-equal environment, fostering greater self-assurance. Conversely, fewer female NU participants reported an increase in self-efficacy. Despite NU's international culture, students still reside in Kazakhstan, where deep-rooted gender stereotypes persist. Hence, female NU alumni may have faced more instances of gender inequality, limiting their ability to enhance their self-efficacy.

Our data show that gender stereotypes and biases still exist in Kazakhstani society, specifically at the organizational level. They are mostly connected to women's roles as primary caregivers within a household with multiple domestic responsibilities, which creates obstacles in terms of achieving professional success (Enkhtur, 2019; Pham and Saito, 2019). However, a more extensive exploration is required to contextualize these findings within the wider context of gender dynamics in Kazakhstani society.

As reported in other studies (Bonilla and Kwak, 2015; Jonbekova

et al., 2023; Perna et al., 2015; Pham and Saito, 2019), our findings maintained that a rigid and toxic work environment discouraged graduates with international diplomas from exercising agency. Field-related challenges differed between Bolashak and NU alumni. NU graduates experienced difficulties in the civil service industry, while Bolashak graduates faced greater issues in underdeveloped industries in Kazakhstan, such as hospitality, economics, finance and investment. Therefore, Kazakhstan has an issue of the domestic economy lagging behind human capital rather than an issue of labor shortage.

Our findings show that both international education obtained abroad and at home contribute to the preparation of globally competitive professionals and enhance their employability. We believe that including more “intercultural dimensions into the formal and informal curriculum” (Beelen and Jones, 2015, p. 69) at domestic universities will be beneficial as it will improve the quality of education and open opportunities for a larger number of nonmobile students to develop global competencies at home countries. It should be noted that in line with the previous studies (Belderbos, 2020; Crossman and Clarke, 2010), our findings indicate that international education at home is not an absolute substitute to study abroad. Those graduates who studied and lived abroad highlighted the importance of intercultural skills and English proficiency for their career more often than their local peers. Moreover, the findings indicate that overseas diplomas are more valued by domestic employers (Jonbekova et al., 2021, 2023). However, at-home international education is reported to assist in developing global, international, and intercultural skills (Beelen and Jones, 2015; Soria and Troisi, 2014) that our findings also reflect. Expensive study abroad programs are limited in creating a widespread effect on national human capital (Agnew and Kahn, 2014), and therefore it is recommended for governments to encourage local universities to use international practices in teaching and campus activities to “stimulate global learning for all” (De Wit and Altbach, 2021, p. 17).

While the study focuses on Kazakhstan, its value extends beyond its immediate geographic focus. Firstly, the problem it addresses is not unique to the country but of global interest, as it pertains to other nations that are concerned with the role of higher education, and international education in particular, in preparing a skilled workforce for building a knowledge-based economy.

From a regional perspective, by offering a nuanced examination of the employment landscape for government scholarship alumni with international education and shedding light on the specific challenges and opportunities faced by those alumni, the study provides tailored insights that can inform policy and practice within the post-Soviet context.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Serkova Yevgeniya: Writing – review & editing. **Jonbekova Dilrabo:** Supervision, Writing – review & editing. **Kim Tatyana:** Writing – review & editing.

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